

While and during

Teaching guide

Connect activities that overlap in time.

Understand the distinction

While commonly introduces a clause: while I was cooking. During is a preposition followed by a noun phrase: during dinner. Both can locate something within another period or event.

While cooking is also possible when the understood subject is clear. While does not require a continuous tense in every context: while I am away is natural. During does not say how long an action lasted; use for with a duration.

Compare the patterns

WHILE + CLAUSE

The phone rang while I was cooking.

A subject and verb follow while.

DURING + NOUN

The phone rang during dinner.

Dinner names the event.

FOR + DURATION

We talked for an hour.

An hour measures the duration.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. I took notes ___ the meeting.

2. Correct this: During I was reading, it began to rain.

3. Which means a duration: during the lesson or for an hour?

Use it in your own life

Describe an interruption during an activity.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. during

The meeting is a noun phrase.

2. While I was reading, it began to rain.

I was reading is a clause.

3. for an hour

During identifies the surrounding event; for gives the length.

One possible response

A friend called while I was making lunch.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-04.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe an interruption during an activity.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.